1932–PRESENT

JOHN "SANDY" WOODWARD

SENIOR COMMANDER OF THE SOUTH ATLANTIC TASK FORCE

After joining the Royal Navy at the age of just 13, John "Sandy" Woodward spent most of his early career on submarines, where he gained his first command, the submarine *Warspite*, in 1969. Promoted to rear admiral in 1981, the following year he was given command of the British Task Force sent to the Falklands. Woodward received a knighthood for his service during the war, finishing his career as a full admiral.



Sound. *Broadsword* was hit by a bomb that failed to explode; *Coventry* was not so lucky. The destroyer was hit by three bombs, two of which exploded. The operations room was devastated, killing or injuring most senior officers. Another victim was the transport ship *Atlantic Conveyor,* sunk by an Exocet missile that ironically had been diverted from its original warship target by the successful use of chaff.

Nonetheless, May 25 proved to be something of a turning point for the British ships around the Falklands. With the Argentine air force unable to sustain its daily losses, British forces were able to establish a degree of air superiority over San Carlos Water. The Harrier jets performed outstandingly, shooting down 32 aircraft for the loss of five of their own—none in air-to-air combat. Thereafter the Argentine air force was able to make only brief assaults, though it would claim many more British lives during the attack on the landing ship *Sir Galahad* at Port Fitzroy on June 8.

THE FALKLANDS WAR

SINKING OF THE BELGRANO



Date May 2, 1982
Forces British: 1 submarine; Argentine: 1 cruiser
Losses British: none; Argentine: 1 cruiser

Location South of Falkland Islands, South Atlantic

The sinking of the Argentine cruiser *General Belgrano* remains one of the most controversial incidents of the Falklands War. By April 30, when the *Belgrano*'s presence was first registered by British surveillance, the Royal Navy had established a circular exclusion zone around the Falkland Islands with a radius of 230 miles (370 km). The *Belgrano*, accompanied by two Argentine destroyers, was actually 40 miles (64 km) outside this exclusion zone and might therefore have been considered safe from attack. The British authorities, however, decided that the *Belgrano* did pose a serious threat to the British Task Force. It was directing aircraft attack missions and carried a powerful array of long-range and anti-aircraft guns. On May 2 the order came from London that the *Belgrano* was to be sunk. The tool for this job was the nuclear-powered submarine *Conqueror*, which had been shadowing the enemy cruiser since April 30. When she received the order to attack, *Conqueror* closed to firing range at 3:57 p.m. on May 2, firing three Mark 8 mod 4 torpedoes. These were old, unguided weapons compared to the modern Tigerfish homing torpedoes the *Conquerer* also had on board at the time, but there were some concerns about the Tigerfish's reliability. Two of the torpedoes, each carrying 800 lb (364 kg) of Torpex explosive, hit the cruiser and detonated, ripping open her hull and killing around 275 men. Within 20 minutes the *Belgrano*'s crew were abandoning ship; many men would float in the South Atlantic for several days, some surviving, some not. In total 321 men out of the *Belgrano*'s crew of 1,000 died in the attack.

Silent hunter
HMS *Conqueror* is the only nuclear-powered submarine to have sunk an enemy ship using torpedoes, and one of only two to have sunk an enemy warship since World War II.



Mark 8 torpedo
Despite carrying modern Mark 24 Tigerfish torpedoes, HMS *Conqueror* opted to use the much older but more reliable Mark 8 torpedo to attack the ARA *Belgrano*.



THE FALKLANDS WAR

SINKING OF THE SHEFFIELD



Date May 4–10, 1982
Forces English: 1 destroyer; Argentine: 2 aircraft
Losses English: 1 destroyer; Argentine: none

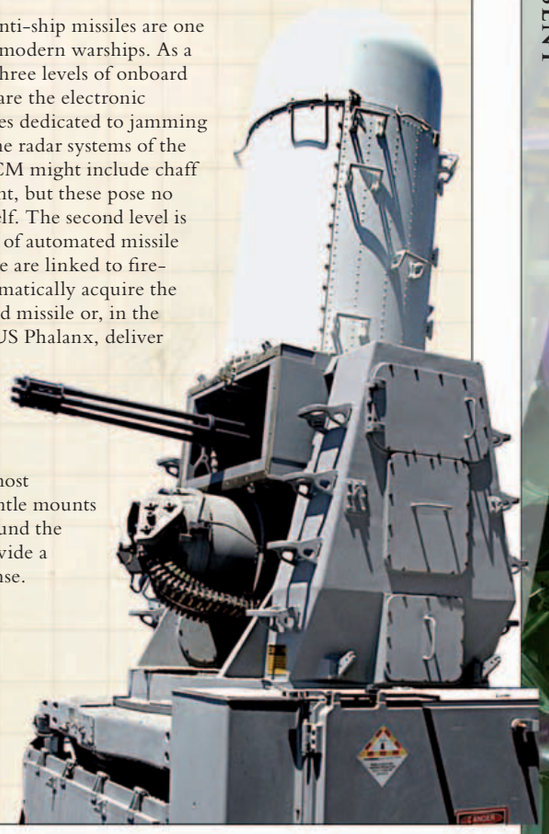
Location Off Port Stanley, Falkland Islands

On May 4, the British Type 42 guided-missile destroyer HMS *Sheffield* was on defensive station off the Falkland Islands when her aging radar systems picked up what appeared to be inbound missiles, although no launch aircraft were detected. Two Exocet anti-ship missiles had however been launched by Argentine Super Etendard aircraft, and only a few seconds after their detection, one of the missiles struck the HMS *Sheffield* amidships. The missile started a raging fire that could not be extinguished because of the destruction of many of the ship's fire-control systems in the initial impact. Eventually the captain gave the order for the ship to be abandoned—21 men had been killed. The stricken ship was towed out to sea and scuttled on May 10. The sinking of the *Sheffield* was the first major loss for the British Task Force around the Falklands—and the first Royal Navy vessel to be sunk in battle for almost 40 years.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

MODERN AIR DEFENSE SYSTEMS

Hostile aircraft armed with anti-ship missiles are one of the most potent threats to modern warships. As a response, navies tend to use three levels of onboard air defense technology. First are the electronic countermeasures (ECM) suites dedicated to jamming missile homing systems, or the radar systems of the attack aircraft themselves. ECM might include chaff and radar-jamming equipment, but these pose no real danger to the aircraft itself. The second level is more aggressive, and consists of automated missile or gun defense systems. These are linked to fire-control systems that can automatically acquire the targets and fire either a guided missile or, in the case of gun systems like the US Phalanx, deliver hails of radar-aimed cannon or machine-gun fire. The final, and most basic, level of air defense is provided by optically aimed machine guns and cannon. Even the most modern vessels often have pintle mounts for machine-guns dotted around the ship's rails, and these can provide a last-ditch method of air defense.



Phalanx anti-missile system
The US Navy's Phalanx close-in weapon system (CIWS) uses an automated radar and fire-control system to track incoming anti-ship missiles and destroy them with its M61 Vulcan cannon.